The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

China criticised America for “unjustly suppressing foreign companies” after the House of Representatives approved a bill that could ban **TikTok** in the country. Shou Chew, TikTok’s boss, urged the social-media platform’s **American** users to “protect” their “constitutional rights”. Should the Senate also pass the bipartisan legislation, Bytedance, TikTok’s Chinese owner, would be forced to sell the app to an owner of another nationality or face a ban in its largest market. Regulators worry that China is using the app to gather Americans’ personal data.

Israel’s army said it wanted to “flood” Gaza with aid via new land routes into the besieged enclave. One such route opened on Tuesday, enabling the first delivery of food into northern Gaza in three weeks. Aid agencies warn that Gazans are on the brink of famine. The EU’s foreign-policy chief says Israel is using starvation as a weapon of war.

Jens Stoltenberg, **NATO’s** secretary-general, rebuked the alliance’s members for “not providing Ukraine with enough ammunition”. But, speaking at the presentation of NATO’s annual report, Mr Stoltenberg also noted that two-thirds of member states would now meet the alliance’s defence-spending target of 2% of GDP this year. Roughly a third of members were thought to meet the target in 2023.

SpaceX, a firm founded by Elon Musk, launched its vast Starship rocket from its base in Texas. The test appears to have been more successful than two missions carried out last year. The two-stage rocket completed its separation manoeuvre and entered space.

SpaceX said it lost contact with the rocket on re-entry into the atmosphere. It was supposed to splashdown in the Indian Ocean.

The **International Energy Agency** revised its forecast for global oil-demand growth to 1.3m barrels a day in 2024. That is an increase of 110,000 b/d compared with a forecast last month, but well below 2.3m b/d in 2023. The world's energy watchdog also lowered its forecast on global supply growth as OPEC+ countries cut production.

A high court in **Japan** ruled that the country's ban on **gay marriage** violated the constitution. The case is now likely to proceed to the Supreme Court. More than two-thirds of Japan's population think same-sex marriage should be legal. But the ruling Liberal Democratic Party opposes it.

On Wednesday the British government introduced legislation to stop the *Telegraph* and the *Spectator* being controlled by a foreign state. *The Economist* has investigated **Sir Frederick and Sir David Barclay**, the twin brothers who bought the titles in 2004, and how their business escaped bankruptcy in the 1970s. As debate rages about who should own the news media, our investigation asks whether the brothers' empire was built on a fraud.

Figure of the day: 40%, the share of China's GDP growth created by clean-energy industries last year. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.

Photo: Reuters

NATO’s secretary-general steps down

After ten years in the job Jens Stoltenberg, NATO’s secretary-general, will deliver his final annual report on Thursday. He leaves the military alliance in good shape. But it is facing great challenges. Because of Vladimir Putin’s aggression against Ukraine, NATO has rediscovered its role as the bastion of European territorial defence against Russia.

Last week, Sweden joined Finland as a new NATO member. Both countries bring sophisticated military capabilities to defending NATO’s border in the Baltics and in the high north. Roughly two-thirds of NATO’s 32 members are on track this year to reach or exceed the target of spending 2% of GDP on defence. And the alliance is currently conducting its biggest exercise since the cold war, involving 90,000 troops.

But the failure to deliver sufficient munitions to Ukraine has allowed Russia, for now, to take the advantage in the war. Perhaps most worrying is the possibility of NATO-hating Donald Trump returning to the White House and effectively taking America out of the alliance.

Photo: Alamy

Foxconn’s next chapter

Foxconn, one of the largest electronics manufacturers in the world, is often regarded as a gauge of economic activity in China, where its largest factories are located. Some analysts also look to its production lines for a sense of how Apple, the American technology giant, is performing. Foxconn’s factories churn out more iPhones than any other company’s. But the Taiwanese group, which just celebrated its 50th anniversary, is trying to shift what it makes and where it makes it.

Analysts therefore watched Foxconn’s fourth-quarter results, released on Thursday, closely. They were looking for a sense of the company’s direction as it moves beyond making phones in China. The signs were good: Foxconn announced profits of $1.6bn between October and December, marking its second consecutive quarter of growth. This suggests that the group’s recent moves—including investing in America and India, and producing more electric vehicles—are paying off. But those changes will, in turn, change how the company copes with the complicated politics of Taiwanese-Chinese-American relations.

Photo: Getty Images

Spain’s amnesty for Catalan separatists

On Thursday the lower house of Spain’s parliament approved an amnesty for those involved in an illegal referendum in 2017 held in a failed push for Catalan independence.

The issue has consumed Spain since last summer. Pedro Sánchez, the prime minister, fell short of a majority in an election in July. To secure the votes of Catalan separatists in parliament he proposed an

amnesty. Mr Sánchez had previously called the issue unconstitutional—after Thursday's vote, though, a member of his Socialist Party welcomed "a time for reconciliation". The leader of the Conservative opposition, meanwhile, called it "submission" to the separatists. The spokeswoman of one separatist party said (as the two main groupings have all along) that "the goal remains independence."

In a twist, on the eve of the vote, the current leader of Catalonia, Pere Aragonès, called snap regional elections for May. The amnesty may allow his rival, Carles Puigdemont, to compete from exile—and perhaps even return as Catalan president.

Photo: AP

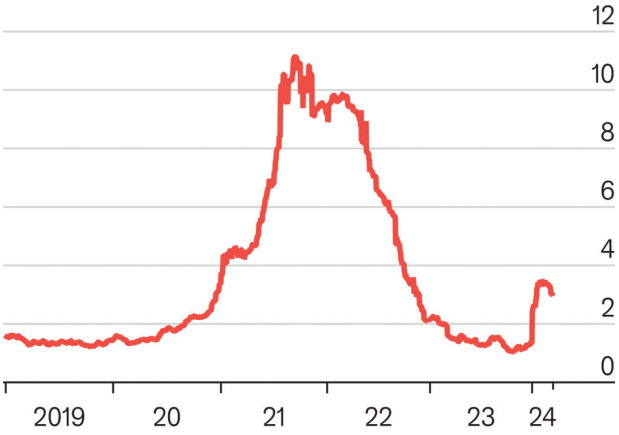
How global shipping is faring

Globalisation's middlemen have had a testing time. Low waters stalled freighters trying to pass through the Panama Canal. Attacks by the Houthis, an Iran-backed Yemeni militia, on ships in the Red Sea shook global trade. The IMF reports that volumes shipped via the Suez Canal—which normally serves around 15% of maritime trade—fell by half in January and February compared with a year earlier. Most have been redirected around southern Africa.

But DP World's full year results for 2023, released on Thursday, gave an early indication that global trade is holding up—for now. The state-owned Emirati firm, which operates ports in roughly 40 countries, reported that its revenues increased by 6.6% year on year but that profits fell because of higher costs. In January its boss, Sultan Ahmed bin Sulayem, seemed unconcerned about the Houthis' attacks. "I don't see this going on long term," he said. Two months later the Red Sea shows no sign of returning to normal. Commenting on his company's earnings, Mr bin Sulayem offered a more pragmatic view of the "deteriorating geopolitical landscape". Commerce is adapting, but it is a struggle.

Dear straits

Global container-freight costs, $'000
Per 40-foot container



Sources: Freightos Baltic Index; LSEG Workspace

Photo: Dave Simonds

Why golfers are feeling flush

Since the launch of the Saudi-funded LIV Tour two years ago, men's golf has been soaked in money. LIV offered enormous salaries to some of the world's best players to persuade them to defect from America's prestigious PGA Tour. Those offers continue to lure them: Tyrrell Hatton, an English player, moved to LIV in January for a reported sum of at least $60m.

The PGA Tour responded by jacking up the prize money at its own events. This year's Players Championship at Sawgrass in Florida, which begins on Thursday, carries a total purse of $25m, making it more lucrative than any of the four majors. The tour also accepted a $3bn investment from Strategic Sports Group, an American consortium, creating a new commercial entity. Crucially, to encourage their loyalty players will get equity stakes in this venture. Golfers are already among the best-paid athletes on the planet. They are about to get richer still.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Thursday: The white rose was the symbol of which English royal house?

Wednesday: Louis Philippe, King of France from 1830 to 1848, stemmed from which cadet branch of the Bourbon family?

> *Life would be tragic if it weren't funny.*
>
> *Stephen Hawking*